

Special addendum: the “9 out of 10 parents” mandate

The “9 out of 10” claim is not simply false. The stronger concern is that it is doing more political work than the evidence can safely carry.

It turns a consultation result into a public mandate. It turns parental anxiety into policy certainty. It turns a routed survey answer into a clean headline. Most importantly, it helps obscure the fact that children and young people did not give the same level of support for a blanket ban.

Plain language translation

At face value

The government is saying:

Most parents want this. Parents are asking for help. Children are being harmed. The government is acting because the public, especially parents, demanded action.

That is a powerful democratic frame. It makes the ban sound not just protective, but authorised.

What’s left unsaid

The figure does not mean “9 out of 10 parents in the UK support this exact ban”. The government’s own ad hoc release says the relevant parental figures came from parents and carers who responded to the full-length consultation, not from a nationally representative sample of all parents. It also says the consultation was self-selecting, meaning it reflected the views of people motivated to take part, not parents and carers nationally. ([GOV.UK](https://gov.uk))

The figure also does not mean children agree with the government’s solution. The progress statement says only 19% of children and young people consulted supported a minimum age of 16 across all social media, while 66% supported age restrictions on at least some social media sites. The government also says children tend to favour a more selective approach, especially restricting features, rather than banning services altogether. ([GOV.UK](https://gov.uk))

Evidence check

Public message

What the evidence says

Why it matters

“9 in 10 parents back the ban”	The government’s progress statement says 90% of parents who responded supported a minimum age of at least 16 for social media. (GOV.UK)	this is strong support among respondents, but it is not the same as a representative poll of all parents
“parents support a ban”	The detailed evidence shows 89% of parent respondents to the relevant question supported a legal minimum age of access. The follow-up question on “at least 16” was only asked after respondents did not reject the first minimum-age question.	support for “some legal minimum age” is being blended with support for a specific under-16 ban
“young people agree”	Only 19% supported a minimum age of 16 across all social media, though 66% supported age restrictions on at least some social media sites. (GOV.UK)	partial support for some restrictions is not the same as youth support for a blanket ban
“overwhelming public demand”	The government says it heard from more than 116,000 people, including more than 54,000 parents and 14,000 children, and also says there were “deeply held, often conflicting” views. (GOV.UK)	the scale of participation is real, but scale does not remove disagreement or policy trade-offs
“therefore this is the right solution”	The consultation asked about benefits, harms, privacy, data, business costs, enforcement and impacts on children’s wellbeing. (GOV.UK)	public support does not prove that the ban will reduce harm, be enforceable, protect privacy or avoid displacement

The routing problem

The most important technical point is the route through the questions.

The consultation first asked whether respondents supported a legal requirement for social media services to have a minimum age of access. In the official evidence summary, 89% of parent respondents to that question answered yes. The next question asked whether social media services should have a minimum age of access of at least 16 and should not be accessible to children under that age. That second question was routed, so it was not a clean question put to everyone regardless of their answer to the first question.

That matters because routed questions can create a cleaner-looking consensus. People who reject the starting premise are removed from the later, more specific question. The official ad

hoc release also warns that the results were self-selecting, not representative of parents and carers nationally, optional, limited to the full-length consultation and provisional at the time of publication. ([GOV.UK](https://www.gov.uk))

A plain version would be:

Among parents who chose to respond to the relevant parts of the consultation, support for a legal minimum age was very strong. Among those routed into the follow-up question, support for age 16 was also very strong. But this is not the same as saying 9 out of 10 UK parents support the final policy as designed.

Euphemism and framing decoder

Phrase	What it sounds like	What it often means
“9 in 10 parents”	near-total parental agreement	strong support among a specific responding group, presented as if it settles the wider debate
“overwhelming public demand”	the country has clearly spoken	a large consultation produced strong parental support, but with caveats about self-selection, routing and youth disagreement
“two-thirds of young people agree”	children broadly support the government’s approach	many young people support some age restrictions, but only a small minority support a 16 minimum across all social media
“we have listened”	the policy follows the evidence neutrally	the government is choosing one interpretation of mixed evidence and using parental support as its clearest mandate
“parents are crying out for change”	urgent need and moral legitimacy	real parental need is used to justify a specific solution before proving that it is enforceable or best matched to children’s needs
“clear line”	certainty and protection	complexity is being compressed into a boundary that may not match how children actually use online spaces

Rhetorical trick

The rhetorical trick is statistical compression.

The government compresses several different things into one clean claim:

Compressed element	What gets lost
parent respondents	all parents
support for a minimum age	support for this specific ban
support for some youth restrictions	support for a blanket social media ban
public demand for action	evidence that this action will work
parental protection needs	children's participation, privacy, access and agency needs
consultation scale	consultation representativeness

This is also a form of mandate inflation. The number is real, but the meaning is expanded. The Unignorable principle “Framing is a Weapon” is relevant here because it warns that positive or authoritative framing can make certain needs unspeakable, especially when the language creates the appearance of legitimacy while hiding trade-offs.

Systems and consequences lens

Ignored needs

The “9 out of 10” frame foregrounds one real need: parents need help.

But it pushes other needs into the background:

Need	How the statistic obscures it
children's voice	children's lower support for a blanket ban becomes less visible
child agency	the policy is framed as something done for children, not with them
safe connection	online friendship, identity, support and learning needs are treated as secondary
privacy	age assurance becomes a technical detail rather than a civil-liberties issue
enforceability	support for a rule is treated as evidence that the rule can work

targeted design reform	the focus shifts from unsafe platform design to child access
marginalised children's support	the needs of LGBTQ+, SEND, isolated or vulnerable children can disappear inside the parent-majority frame
trust	using a simplified statistic risks making the consultation look like justification after the fact rather than open evidence-gathering

The user-needs guidance is directly relevant here. It says needs should focus on the real user problem, not a preferred solution. It also warns that public or charitable services can be shaped by institutional assumptions or policy mandates instead of authentic user needs.

Short-term

The number gives the government a strong public shield. It makes the policy feel democratic, urgent and parent-led. It reduces the political cost of acting quickly.

Medium-term

The same number can weaken scrutiny. MPs, media and the public may spend less time asking whether the ban is enforceable, whether it will push children elsewhere, whether age assurance protects privacy, and whether young people's concerns have been addressed.

Long-term

If the policy fails, the "9 out of 10" claim may damage trust. People may feel the consultation was used to legitimise a decision rather than to test competing solutions. Children who felt unheard may also become less likely to trust official safety messaging.

Decoded

The surface claim is: parents want protection.

The deeper function is: the government is using parental support to convert a contested and technically difficult policy into an apparently settled moral mandate.

Control spectrum lens

Who's speaking	Claimed concern	Actual control goal
government	parents overwhelmingly want protection	secure legitimacy for a fast, visible intervention

ministers	“we have listened”	present the chosen policy as the natural result of consultation
parents who support the ban	children need safety and boundaries	gain a shared rule so individual parents are not left alone against platforms and peer pressure
children and young people	online spaces need to be safer	preserve useful access while restricting harmful features
platforms	comply with the new rules	shape definitions, verification methods and exemptions
Ofcom	enforce effective rules	turn political intent into workable age-assurance and compliance systems
age assurance providers	prove age accurately	become essential infrastructure for access to online services
wider public	understand what the evidence shows	avoid being guided by a clean statistic that hides caveats

Key inversion

The government uses a parent-majority statistic to justify a policy imposed mainly on children.

That is the inversion.

The people who carry the direct loss of access are children. Yet the headline mandate is drawn from adults. This does not make the adults wrong. Parents have real fears and real responsibilities. But it does mean the statistic can make children’s own views appear secondary, even though the government says children’s voices were put “front and centre”. ([GOV.UK](https://www.gov.uk))

The sharper civic point is:

The “9 out of 10” number proves parental demand for help. It does not prove child consent, policy effectiveness, national consensus or platform safety.

Timeline reframing

Time frame	Consequence of using the “9 out of 10” frame	Consequence of a more honest frame
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Short-term	the government gains a clear mandate and reduces opposition	the government still shows strong parental concern, but admits that children's views are mixed
Medium-term	policy scrutiny narrows around whether one supports parents or platforms	scrutiny focuses on enforceability, displacement, privacy, youth support and safer design
Long-term	trust may erode if the ban does not reduce harm or is widely bypassed	trust is more likely to hold because the public was warned about trade-offs from the start

Honest reframes

1. "Parents who responded to the consultation strongly support a higher minimum age, but this does not settle whether a blanket ban is the best solution."
2. "Children and young people are not rejecting safety. They are more often asking for targeted restrictions, safer features and continued access to useful online spaces."
3. "The consultation shows strong demand for action, not automatic proof that this action will work."
4. "The government is choosing to prioritise parental support for a clear age rule over children's preference for a more selective approach."
5. "A large number of responses does not remove the need to test representativeness, question routing, policy scope and real-world outcomes."
6. "The policy should be judged by reduced harm, not by the popularity of the announcement."
7. "The clearest finding is not simply 'ban social media'. It is that parents want help, children want safer online life, and platforms have failed to design safe environments."

Needs table

Actor	Stated needs	Unstated needs	Impact of outcome
government	show that it has listened and is protecting children	turn consultation support into a strong political mandate	gains legitimacy, but risks being accused of overstating the evidence
parents who support the ban	protect children from harm and reduce household conflict	avoid being the only family enforcing limits	gain a shared rule, but may still face workarounds and enforcement burdens

children under 16	be safe online	keep access to friendship, learning, identity, support and creativity	may gain protection from some harms, but may lose useful and safe spaces
young people who favour targeted restrictions	reduce harmful features	avoid losing whole services because of risky design choices	their view is partly acknowledged but diluted by the parent headline
marginalised children	be protected from online harm	retain private routes to support, identity and trusted advice	risk being treated as an exception rather than a core design test
Ofcom	enforce workable online safety rules	receive clear scope, powers and evidence	becomes responsible for turning a popular claim into a workable system
platforms	comply with age restrictions	preserve core business models and influence implementation	may shift the debate towards age gates rather than redesign
public	understand the evidence behind the policy	receive caveats, not just headline numbers	may be misled if consultation support is presented as proof of effectiveness

Addendum conclusion

The “9 out of 10” line should stay in the analysis, but it should be treated as a warning sign, not just a statistic.

It is strong evidence that many participating parents want firmer action. It is not strong evidence that the final policy is enforceable, proportionate, privacy-preserving, or aligned with children’s own views.

The key Unignorable judgement is this:

The government is using a real parental concern to create a simplified mandate. That mandate obscures the more difficult truth: children need safety, but they also need agency, connection, support, privacy and learning. A policy that quotes parents loudly while summarising children selectively risks protecting the idea of childhood more clearly than it protects actual children.

According to documents published in June 2026, the data shows a real child-safety problem, strong parental demand for action, and much weaker evidence for a blanket ban as the preferred solution. The government's "9 in 10 parents" line is not made up, but it is an over-compressed reading of a much more mixed evidence base.

Better overview of what the data shows

The clearest summary

The data supports this conclusion:

Parents strongly want government action on children's social media use. Many support an under-16 age limit. But the most reliable data does not show a simple national consensus for a blanket ban as the best solution. Children and young people mostly prefer selective restrictions, such as restricting some platforms, risky functions, stranger contact, livestreaming, addictive design features and time-based controls.

That is the core point the government's headline obscures.

The government is using several different evidence sources as if they say one thing

The consultation was not one single clean poll. It included open consultation responses, parent and carer surveys, children and young people's surveys, nationally representative panel surveys, campaign responses and email submissions. The official response totals show 116,211 responses in total, but the routes were very different: 24,534 full consultation responses, 39,116 parent and carer survey responses, 5,113 children and young people's survey responses, 5,011 parent and carer panel responses, 9,017 children and young people panel responses, 33,141 campaign responses and 279 email responses. Only the panel surveys were designed to be nationally representative. The open surveys were self-selecting and cannot be used to draw national conclusions on their own. ([GOV.UK](https://gov.uk))

That distinction matters. A self-selecting consultation can show intensity and mobilisation. It can show that many people care strongly. It cannot, by itself, show that 9 out of 10 parents nationally support the final policy.

What the parent data really shows

There is no doubt that parent concern is strong. The government's ad hoc release says that among parents and carers of children aged 21 or under who responded to Question 12 in the full-length consultation, 89% supported a legal requirement for social media services to have a minimum age of access. But Question 13, the more specific question about age 16, was only shown to people who had already answered "yes" to supporting a minimum age in principle. Among that filtered group, 96% agreed to some extent that the minimum age should be at least 16. The government itself warns that this was self-selecting, routed, limited to the full-length consultation, and not representative of parents nationally. ([GOV.UK](https://gov.uk))

The more representative parent data is still supportive, but less overwhelming. In the nationally representative panel survey, 76% of parents agreed that social media should have a minimum age of access of at least 16, with 47% strongly agreeing. In the public consultation parent survey, support rose to 91%, with 82% strongly agreeing. This is exactly what you would expect if people motivated to answer an open consultation were more restriction-favouring than the wider parent population.

So the cleaner reading is:

Claim	Better reading
"9 in 10 parents back the ban"	9 in 10 parent respondents in some open consultation routes backed strong age restrictions
"parents nationally overwhelmingly back this exact policy"	the representative parent panel shows strong majority support, but at 76%, not 90%
"parents prefer a blanket ban"	many parents support a ban, but when alternatives are compared, representative-panel parents often prefer targeted restrictions

The most important overlooked finding is that representative-panel parents did not rank the blanket ban first when asked to compare options. In the panel survey, 44% of parents ranked a minimum age for the most risky functions first, 31% ranked time restrictions first, and only 16% ranked a blanket social media ban first. By contrast, open consultation parents put the blanket

ban first by 63%. That split shows why the government's preferred figure matters politically: it chooses the most pro-ban evidence stream as the public headline.

What the children and young people data shows

The children and young people data points in a different direction.

The government's own progress statement says only 19% of consulted children and young people supported a minimum age of 16 across all social media platforms. It also says 66% supported age restrictions on at least some social media sites. The same statement says children tend to favour a more selective approach, restricting different functions or services rather than banning access altogether. ([GOV.UK](https://gov.uk))

The Savanta quantitative report gives a fuller picture. In the nationally representative panel survey of children and young people aged 10 to 21, 29% supported a rule that only people aged 16 or older should use social media. The most common answer was selective access: 48% said children younger than 16 should be allowed to use some platforms but not others. Another 19% said under-16s should be allowed to use all platforms. In the public consultation sample, only 19% supported a full ban, 47% favoured selective access, and 34% would allow under-16s to use all platforms.

The most directly affected age groups were even less supportive of a full ban. Among 10- to 12-year-olds in the panel survey, 18% supported a full ban and 53% preferred selective access. Among 13- to 15-year-olds, 17% supported a full ban and 53% preferred selective access. That means the children closest to being banned were not mostly saying "do nothing". They were mostly saying "restrict some things, not everything".

That is the data point to make unignorable:

The government's "two-thirds of young people agree" line refers to support for restrictions on at least some social media sites, not support for a blanket under-16 ban across all social media.

The strongest area of agreement is targeted restriction, not blanket exclusion

The data shows more common ground around feature-level restrictions than around a full ban. Around three quarters of both parents and children and young people in the representative panel agreed that restricting certain features would make children's online experience safer. The report says this shared concern focused especially on contact with unknown users, sharing sensitive content and sharing other personal information.

This is crucial. The strongest shared mandate is not "ban children from social media". It is "make risky features unavailable or harder to access". That supports a policy focused on stranger

contact, livestreaming, location sharing, algorithmic amplification, infinite scroll, autoplay, disappearing content, image sharing and sexually explicit AI chatbot features.

The representative-panel evidence also points towards time-based controls. The Savanta report says 89% of parents and 84% of children and young people in the panel supported daily app-level limits, overnight restrictions, or both. That again suggests broader agreement around targeted controls than around a blanket access ban.

The usage data shows why parents are worried

The evidence does support the view that social media is deeply embedded in young people's lives. In the Savanta panel data, 97% of children and young people had access to a smartphone and 96% reported using social media. Use reached near-universal levels by age 13. The same report found that children and young people reported spending an average of 4.2 hours per day on social media, while parents estimated 2.7 hours.

The Commons Library briefing, drawing on Ofcom's 2025 data, gives a similar picture for younger children. It reports that mobile phone ownership rises from 19% among 3- to 5-year-olds to 97% among 13- to 15-year-olds. It also says 95% of 13- to 15-year-olds use social media and 96% of that age group have their own social media profile. It even reports that 37% of 3- to 5-year-olds use social media, with 60% of that group having their own profile.

So the government is not wrong to say there is a real problem of scale. Social media is not a small side activity for older children. It is part of daily life.

The same usage data also shows why a blunt ban is difficult

The data also shows why the ban is hard to enforce and easy to oversimplify. Social media is not only a harmful content channel. Children and young people also describe it as a place for connection, inclusion, learning and support. In the Savanta panel, 82% of children and young people agreed that social media helps them feel connected to other people, and 71% said it makes them feel included. The government's own progress statement says children described online life as a way to learn skills, connect with friends, feel less alone, access information and find help, especially for some marginalised groups.

This does not cancel the harms. It changes the policy test. If children use online spaces for friendship, learning, identity and support, then a ban needs to show where those needs will go. Otherwise the policy may reduce visible access while creating hidden need.

The harm data is real, but uneven

The data does not support a complacent “children are fine online” view. There are real harms. The Commons Library briefing summarises risks including child sexual abuse material, unhealthy body image, eating disorder content, self-harm, suicide content, pornography, violent content, cyberbullying and harassment.

But the evidence also shows that harm is unevenly distributed. The Commons Library briefing cites Ofcom data showing that girls were more likely than boys to report hurtful online interactions, at 34% compared with 28%. It also reports that children aged 8 to 17 with an impacting condition, such as a disability, were more likely than their counterparts to say they had seen worrying or nasty online content, at 41% compared with 31%.

That matters because a blanket ban treats “children” as one group. The data suggests that risk varies by age, gender, disability, platform, feature, time of use and social context. A needs-centred policy would track which children are most at risk, which features cause the risk, and what support is lost if access is removed.

The expected impact data shows the enforcement problem

Parents and children expect different things from a ban.

In the representative parent panel, the most common expected benefits were fewer children being exposed to inappropriate or harmful content, at 48%, children being safer online, at 45%, and parents feeling more confident that platforms are safe, at 40%. But even parents saw circumvention as a major issue, with 39% expecting children to get around the rules.

Children and young people were more focused on the practical and social consequences. In the representative children and young people panel, the most common expected outcome was that children would try to get around the rules, at 48%. This was followed by children feeling upset or angry, at 41%, feeling left out, at 39%, and finding new ways to talk online, at 35%.

That is a serious warning. The people most affected by the ban think the most likely result is evasion. That does not prove the policy will fail, but it means enforceability cannot be treated as a detail to solve later.

The Australian data is a warning about measuring the right thing

The Australian evidence does not say bans do nothing. It says bans can reduce some account ownership while still leaving a substantial enforcement gap. The Commons Library briefing says Australia’s March 2026 compliance update found that a significant number of under-16 accounts had been removed, deactivated or restricted, but that a substantial number of children under 16 retained accounts. It also summarises a June 2026 research study which found that the early

period after Australia's ban involved limited implementation, incomplete compliance and substantial circumvention.

That gives the UK a clear measurement problem. If success is measured by accounts removed, the ban can look effective. If success is measured by reduced harm, reduced displacement, fewer workarounds, better reporting, less exposure to harmful content and stronger child wellbeing, the test is much harder.

The better headline

A more accurate headline would be:

"Parents strongly support government action, and many support an age-16 rule, but young people mostly prefer selective restrictions. The broadest consensus is for targeted limits on risky features, not a simple blanket ban."

A sharper version for the Unignorable report would be:

"The data does not show a clean public mandate for a blanket social media ban. It shows a real safety problem, strong parental anxiety, and broad support for action. But it also shows that children and young people favour selective restrictions, that parents in representative polling are open to targeted alternatives, and that both parents and children expect enforcement problems. The government's '9 in 10' line takes the most politically useful part of the evidence and lets it stand in for the whole."

What the government can fairly claim

The government can fairly say:

Fair claim	Why it is supported
many parents want stronger rules	parent support for age restrictions is high across multiple sources
there is real concern about harm	evidence identifies harmful content, risky contact, addictive design and uneven impacts

social media use is widespread among children

panel and Ofcom data show high use, especially among older children

targeted feature restrictions have broad support

parents and children show strong agreement on restricting risky features

a ban may reduce some access

Australian evidence suggests some accounts can be removed or restricted

What the government should not imply

The government should not imply:

Weak claim

Why it is misleading

9 out of 10 UK parents support the final policy

the 9 in 10 figure comes from consultation respondents, not a national parent poll

children broadly support a blanket ban

only 19% in the public consultation sample and 29% in the representative panel supported a full ban

two-thirds of young people back the government's approach

the two-thirds figure is about at least some restrictions, not a blanket age-16 ban

a ban is clearly the best-supported option

representative-panel parents often preferred targeted restrictions when asked to compare options

account removal equals safety

Australian evidence shows account reduction can coexist with continued access and circumvention

online access is mostly harmful

the evidence also shows connection, inclusion,
learning and support benefits

Colophon

This analysis was generated by [Unignorable](#), a civic clarity assistant designed to surface hidden needs, assumptions, and consequences beneath civic and political language, clearly, plainly, and without jargon. Made by [Happygeneralist](#), Ryan Haney.